

Theories on Ethics and Ethical Consumption



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Ethics and Morality:

Ethics

- Ethics is the **systematic reflection on what is moral**.
- It examines whether actions, decisions, policies, and behaviours are right or wrong.
- Ethics requires us to think critically about the reasons behind our decisions.

Morality

- Morality refers to the **opinions, decisions, and actions** through which individuals or groups express what they believe is good or right.
- Moral beliefs can influence personal behaviour and social practices.

Simple distinction:

Morality = what people believe is right or wrong

Ethics = systematic thinking about why it is right or wrong

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Ethics: What Is Morally Acceptable?

Ethical values help us determine whether an action or policy is:

1. Morally required

- The action **should be performed**.
- Not performing it would be considered morally wrong.

2. Morally permissible

- The action is **acceptable**, although it may not be compulsory.
- More than one ethically acceptable option may exist.

3. Morally wrong

- The action violates important moral principles or responsibilities.

Examples in engineering

- Protecting public safety
- Providing accurate technical information
- Avoiding deliberate harm
- Considering environmental consequences



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Engineering Ethics:

Engineering ethics concerns the **responsibilities and rights** that should be upheld by people engaged in engineering.

It also includes:

- Professional responsibilities
- Desirable professional ideals
- Personal commitments
- Ethical decision-making in engineering practice
- Ethical responsibilities in engineering research

Why is engineering ethics important?

Engineering decisions can affect:

- Human life and safety
- Public health
- Infrastructure
- Natural resources
- Environmental quality
- Future generation



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Normative Relativism:

Basic idea

Normative relativism argues that:

- Moral values can be **relative**.
- Moral norms may differ between people, societies, cultures, and situations.
- What is considered responsible in one context may not necessarily be considered responsible in another.

According to this view

There are no completely universal guidelines about behaviour that are independent of:

- Time
- Place
- Culture
- Social context



Example: A practice considered socially acceptable in one culture may be viewed differently in another.

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Universalism:

Basic idea

Universalism argues that some moral norms and values can be **universally applicable**.

They should apply to people regardless of:

- Culture
- Location
- Time period
- Social background



Absolutism

A stronger form of universalism argues that certain moral rules should always apply.

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Important distinction:

Universalism does not necessarily mean that **every** moral rule is universal.

For example:

- Protecting human life may be regarded as a fundamental principle.
- However, difficult circumstances may create situations requiring careful ethical judgment.

Engineering application:

Public safety and prevention of avoidable harm can be treated as fundamental professional responsibilities.

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Utilitarianism:

Utilitarianism evaluates an action according to its **overall consequences**.

An action is considered good when it produces:

- More happiness
- Less suffering
- Greater overall benefit

Greatest Happiness Principle

The preferred action is the one that: **Maximizes positive outcomes for the largest number of people** and minimizes negative outcomes.

Engineering example:

Suppose an infrastructure project:

- Benefits thousands of people
- But creates environmental costs for a smaller population.



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What Is Consumption?

Basic meaning: Consumption means **satisfying human needs**.

When a need is fulfilled:

- It may provide pleasure or satisfaction.
- When a need remains unfulfilled, it may produce discomfort or pain.

Consumption is more than using products

Consumption can also be:

- An interpretation process
- A communication process
- A means of expressing identity
- A means of establishing social position

Examples: People may purchase:

- Clothing to express identity
- Cars to demonstrate status
- Electronic devices to communicate social position



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Modern Consumption: A Challenge for Sustainable Development:

Modern consumption creates several major challenges.

Challenge 1 — Inequality: Consumption is distributed very unequally across the world.

Higher-income groups generally consume substantially more:

- Energy, Food
- Materials
- Transport
- Consumer goods

Challenge 2 — Welfare: Increasing consumption does

not necessarily lead to:

- Greater happiness
- Greater social welfare
- Better quality of life

Challenge 3 — Environmental pressure: Increasing consumption creates pressure on:

- Natural resources, Land
- Water, Energy systems
- Ecosystems

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Inequality in Global Consumption:

- First, consumption patterns are inequitable.
- The richest 20% of the world's population consume **11 times as much meat** as the poorest 20%. They consume **17 times as much energy**, **77 times as much paper**, and **145 times as many cars** (UNDP, 1998).



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Meat Consumption:

Example: Average annual meat consumption:

USA: ~127 kg/person

Nigeria: ~7 kg/person

DR Congo: ~3 kg/person



Automobile Consumption:

- Vehicle ownership is concentrated in developed countries.
- High vehicle use increases fossil fuel consumption and emissions.



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Direct and Indirect Environmental Impacts:

Human consumption affects the environment in **two major ways**.

Direct impacts

Direct impacts result from the actual use of natural resources.

Examples: Food, Seafood, Meat, Wood, Water, Energy

Indirect impacts

Indirect impacts occur during the **production and delivery** of goods.

These include: Resource extraction, Manufacturing, Processing, Transportation, Packaging and Waste disposal



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Environmental Impacts of Consumption:

Modern consumerism as a major challenge to environmental sustainability.

Major consequences

Food

- Large quantities of food are wasted.
- Food production itself requires land, water, energy, and other resources.

Water

- Water can be wasted and polluted faster than natural systems can restore its quality.

Energy

- Fossil-fuel combustion provides energy for buildings, factories, and households.
- It is a major source of greenhouse-gas emissions.

Agriculture

Unsustainable agricultural practices can cause: Soil erosion, Water pollution, Declining soil fertility, Environmental degradation

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Sustainable Consumption:

Sustainable consumption means using products and services that:

- Fulfil human needs
- Reduce negative environmental impacts
- Use resources responsibly
- Consider social consequences

Ethical consumer decisions:

Before purchasing a product, consumers can ask:

1. How was it produced?
2. What resources were used?
3. Were workers treated fairly?
4. What environmental impacts occurred?
5. Can the product be reused or repaired?
6. What happens when the product is discarded?



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Ethical Consumption: The Mica Example

Mica in Cosmetics: Used in blush, eye shadow, bronzers, foundation, lipstick, and mascara.

Global Sources: Brazil, Canada, China, Madagascar, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and the United States.

Social Concern: Mica mining in Jharkhand and Bihar, India, has been associated with child labour in small-scale mines.

Ethical Question:

Should consumers consider not only a product's price and quality, but also how its ingredients are sourced?



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Why Sustainable Consumption Matters

1. **Equality** – Fairer access and use of resources.
2. **Reuse & Recycling** – Reuse, repair, recycle, and reduce unnecessary purchases.
3. **Environmental Protection** – Reduce resource depletion, pollution, waste, and ecosystem damage.
4. **Better Working Conditions** – Promote worker safety and healthy workplaces.
5. **Longer Product Life** – Reduce waste, resource extraction, and energy use.

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How Can We Achieve Sustainable Consumption?

Individual: Buy only what is needed; choose durable products; repair, reuse, and recycle.

Institutional: Improve environmental standards; promote responsible production; ensure transparent product information and worker safety.

Government & Policy: Regulate harmful practices; increase accountability; encourage sustainable production; promote responsible advertising.

Social: Encourage public discussion of environmental and human impacts and build a culture of ethical consumption.

Thank you all
